

Optimization Experiments

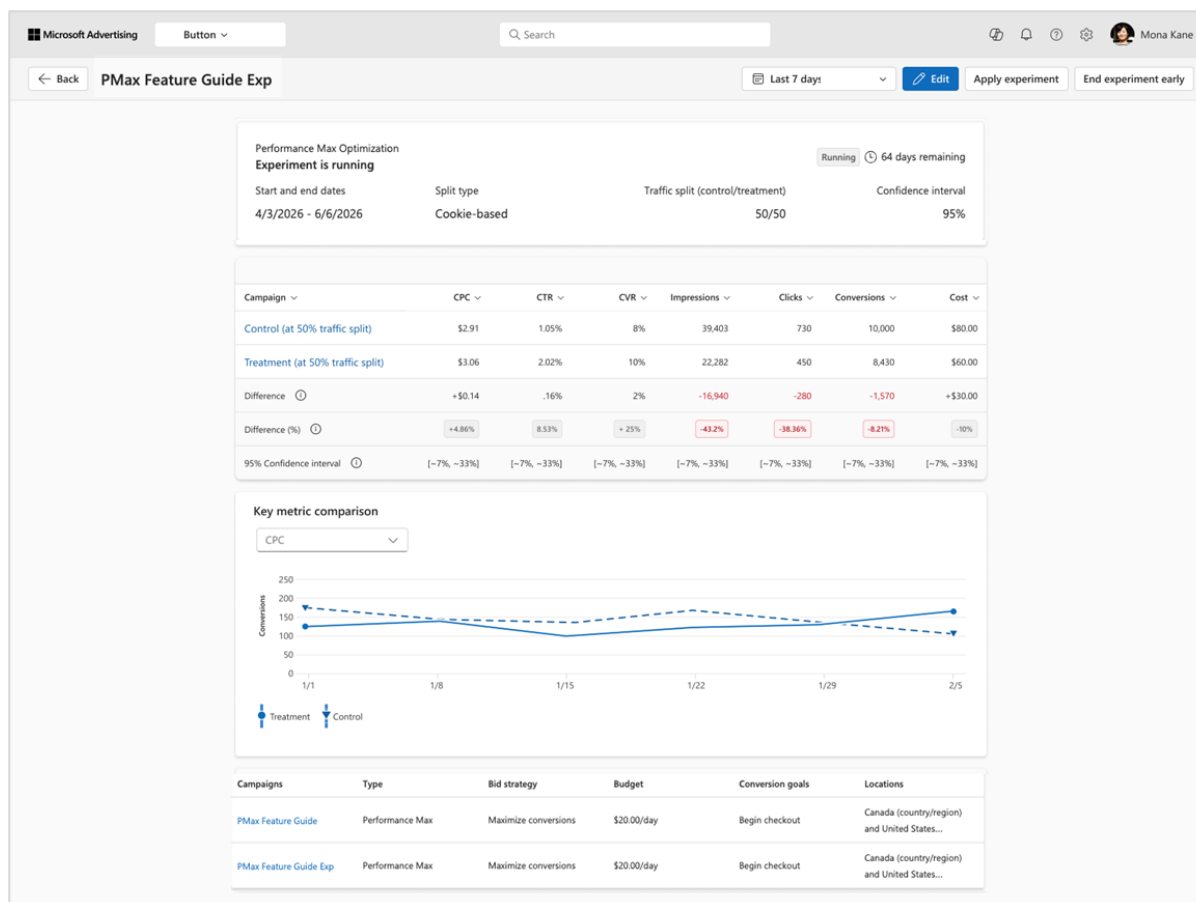
For Shopping, Audience and
Performance Max Campaigns

 Microsoft Advertising



Why Optimization Experiments?

Test with confidence before you commit. Measure the impact of a specific campaign optimization in a controlled A/B test so you have proof before you scale.



Make evidence-based decisions

Use statistically significant results, not guesswork.

Minimize performance risk.

Validate bidding, targeting, creative, and other campaign changes before scaling.

Act on results quickly

Apply winning experiments to your original or a new campaign in one click.

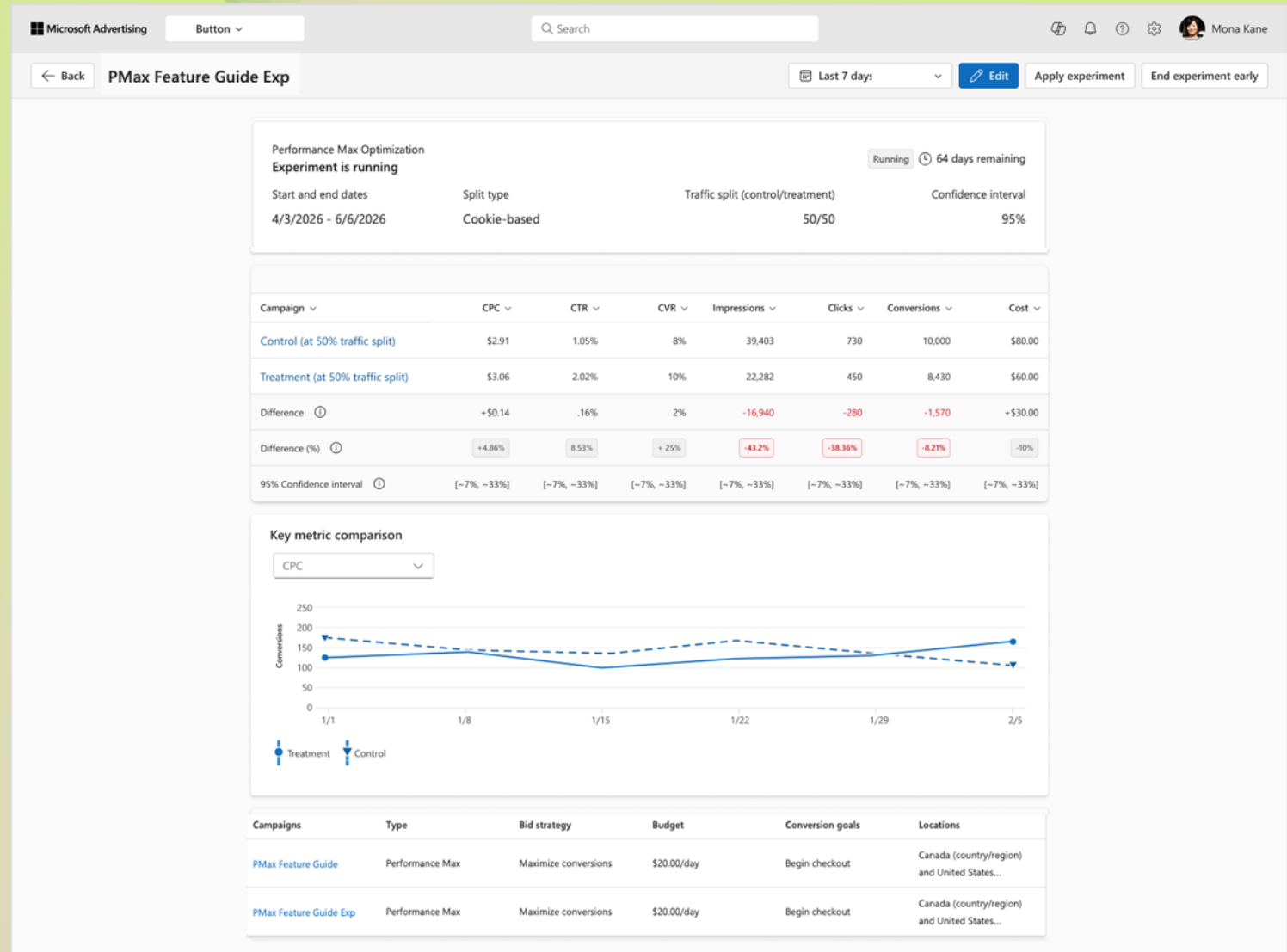
New in Optimization Experiments

1. Optimization Experiments now support non-Search campaigns:

- Shopping
- Audience
- Performance Max

2. New experiment results page:

- A unified results view brings experiment setup and key metrics into one place
- A line-chart visualization makes it easy to compare treatment vs. control
- A campaign details table provides quick reference for experiment settings



Availability information



Status

Closed beta



Markets

Global (excluding China)



Languages

English



Entry points

Online
API



Device

All devices



Network traffic

O&O and syndication

Use cases and best practices

What campaign variables can I test with Optimization Experiments?

Bidding strategies

- Compare an automated-bidding strategy, such as **Maximize Clicks or Target Cost Per Acquisition (CPA)**, with manual bidding or with tool provider version.

Creatives

- If you're unsure whether a **new ad message, ad extensions or creative** will perform better, test it using an optimization experiment and compare results to see what's most effective.

Audience targeting

- Try **targeting a different audience** and see how your performance compares.

How to run an Optimization Experiment?

Step 1

Create experiment and cloned campaign

Select the control campaign and the experiment start and end dates. The treatment campaign is automatically created as a copy of the control campaign

Step 2

Validate baseline performance

Run both campaigns (control and experiment) identically to establish a baseline to ensure A/B testing can be properly attributed to your test variable

Step 3

Apply changes & run A/B test

Apply one optimization variable to the treatment campaign and clearly measure impact

Step 4

Review results & take action

Apply, extend, or end the treatment campaign based on statistically significant results

Best Practices



Campaign Selection

- Use high-volume campaigns when possible, otherwise experiments may require longer experiment durations to reach statistical significance.
- Campaigns using shared or lifetime budgets are currently not supported.
- A campaign cannot participate in multiple experiments that will be active at the same time.



Traffic Split

- Use a 50/50 traffic split to gather volume quickly and make comparisons easier.
- Experiment traffic split cannot be changed once an experiment is running.
- Results are automatically normalized so you can compare treatment (clicks, conversions, conversion value, cost, and impressions) and control fairly.

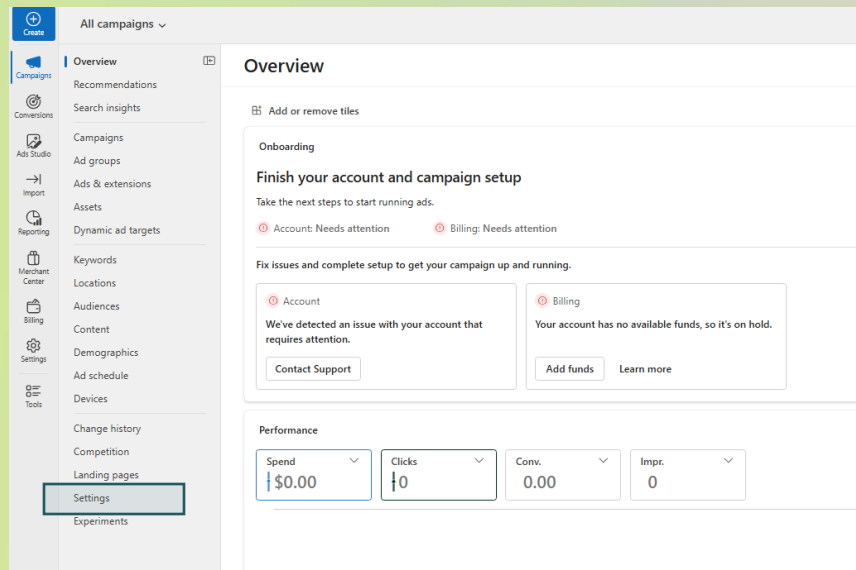


Experiment Launch

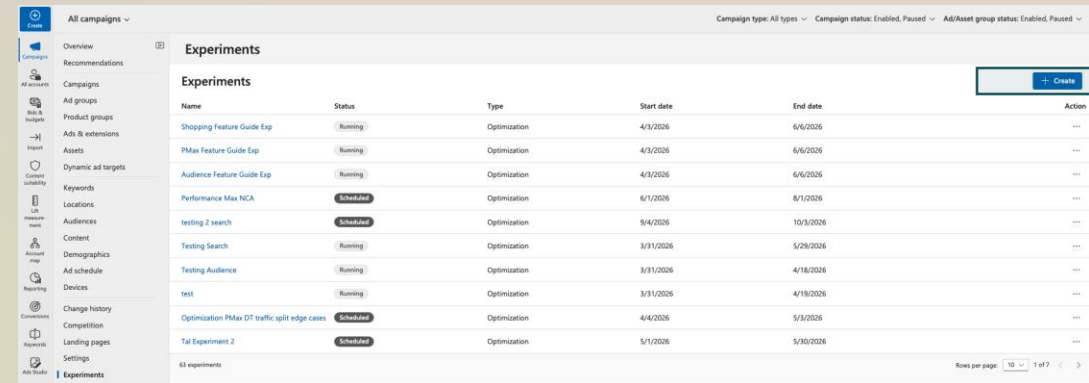
- Test only one variable at a time.
- Run the baseline experiment (A/A) for 2-4 weeks and keep the campaigns identical to achieve a common performance to ensure A/B testing can be properly attributed to your test variable
- Switch to A/B mode for at least 2 weeks (ideally 4 weeks).

Step 1: Create an optimization experiment (1 of 2)

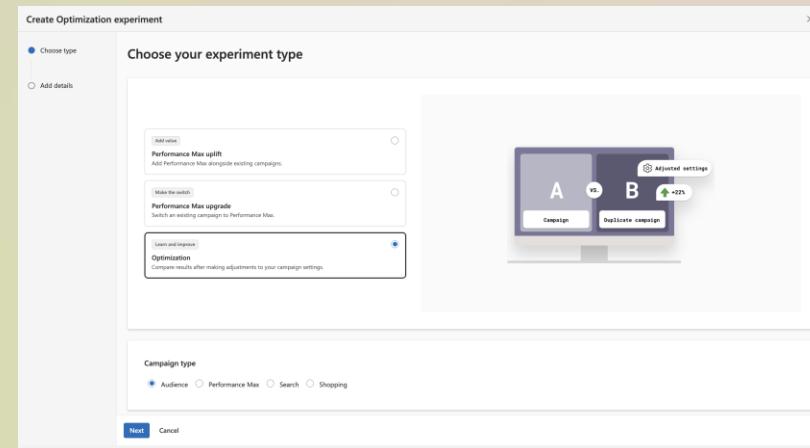
1. Go to the Campaigns page and navigate to the Experiments tab.



2. Click Create



3. Choose Optimization as an experiment type



Step 1: Create an optimization experiment (2 of 2)

- Fill out **Experiment Details**:
 - Choose your control campaign
 - Select **Start and End dates*** that account for both A/A and A/B phases (4-8 weeks total)
 - Set your **Experiment split**. This is the percentage of the original campaign's daily budget and ad traffic that you want to allocate to the treatment campaign.
- Note:** Experiment split cannot be changed once an experiment is running
- Name your experiment
- Review the setup details, then click **Create**

*Experiments are limited to a maximum duration of six months.

Create Optimization experiment

Choose type

- Choose type
- Add details

Experiment details

Performance Max campaign

Select an existing campaign. A copy of it will be used for the treatment campaign with settings that you'll adjust.

Choose Performance Max campaign

Details

Start date *

Select a date

End date *

Select a date

Experiment split (select how much ad traffic you want directed to the treatment campaign)

50 %

Individuals will only see ads from either the control or treatment campaign using cookie-based tracking. [Learn more](#)

Experiment name *

Experiment name

Summary

Control group		Treatment group
Existing campaign		Copy of existing campaign + adjusted settings
Number of campaigns	v.	Number of campaigns
--		--
Estimated budget		Estimated budget
--		--

Details

Experiment name	--
Start date	MM/DD/YYYY
End date	MM/DD/YYYY
Experiment split (control/treatment)	50/50
Split option	Cookie-based
Estimated budget	--

Back Create Cancel

Step 2: Validate A/A setup and establish the baseline

- Once you've created your experiment, it will appear on the **Experiments tab**.
 - Run control and treatment identically for 2–4 weeks to **validate baseline performance**
 - Monitor and review A/A results** before applying changes
 - If there are setup errors with your experiment's creation, there will be a **Download errors** link in the **Actions** column.
- You can also access your experiments from the **All Campaigns** view and within the corresponding original campaign.

After creating your experiment, launch it and run control and treatment identically for 2–4 weeks to establish reliable baseline before introducing changes

Experiments					
Experiments					+ Create
Name	Status	Type ↑	Start date	End date	Action
Nikhil-TestExperiment	Completed	Optimization	2/20/2026	3/1/2026	...
Ethan opt experiment	Running	Optimization	3/6/2026	5/10/2026	...
riley opt test	Running	Optimization	3/24/2026	5/1/2026	...
Optimization - Shopping - MA - BB - renamed	Scheduled	Optimization	4/15/2026	4/22/2026	...
hayley-experiments	Running	Optimization	3/27/2026	8/1/2026	...
Audience optimization	Running	Optimization	3/27/2026	4/1/2026	...
hayley	Running	Optimization	3/31/2026	4/11/2026	...
Tal negative	Completed	Optimization	3/27/2026	3/29/2026	...
Tal Negative Minus 50	Completed	Optimization	3/27/2026	3/28/2026	...
Optimization Shopping Apply	Completed (Applied)	Optimization	3/27/2026	3/30/2026	...
59 experiments			Rows per page: 10 1 of 6		

Step 3: Edit your treatment campaign settings and run an A/B test

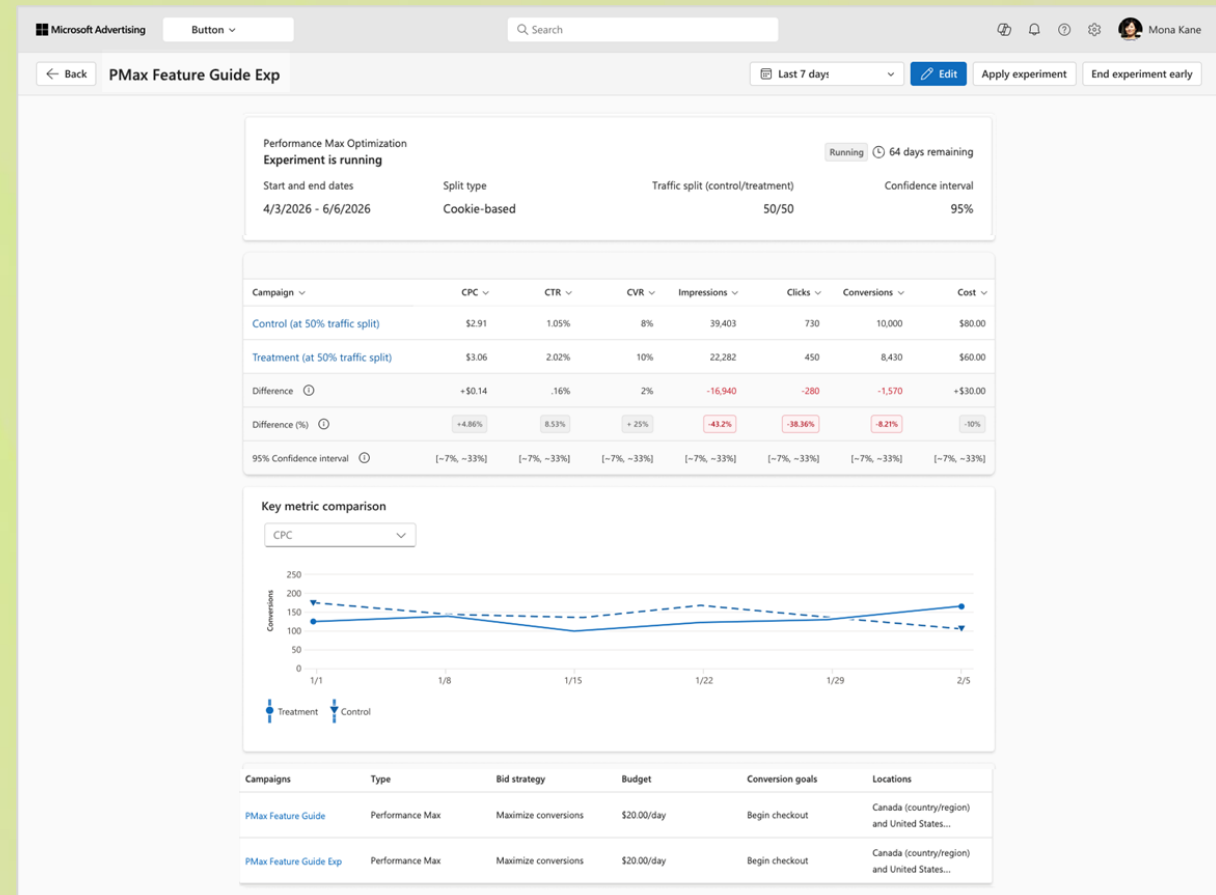
- Open the experiment and **go to Settings** to begin editing the treatment campaign.
 - We recommend that you **apply one optimization variable** to the treatment campaign
 - **You can't change experiment budget.** To change budget, you need to update the original campaign budget. Spend will then be divided according to the new split setting.
- Run the A/B test for 2–4 weeks before reviewing results.

The screenshot shows the 'Campaign settings' page for an experiment named 'PMax Feature Guide Exp'. The left sidebar contains navigation links: Overview, Recommendations, Asset groups, Extensions, Assets, Negative keywords, Locations, Change history, Landing pages, **Settings** (highlighted), Lift measurement, Account map, Reporting, Conversions, Keywords, Ads Studio, Merchant Center, Property Center, Bulk actions, and Tools. The main content area is divided into sections: 'Campaign name' with a text field containing 'PMax Feature Guide Exp' and a character count; 'Bid strategy' with a dropdown set to 'Maximize conversions' and an unchecked checkbox for 'Set a target cost per acquisition (CPA) (Optional)'; 'Budget' with a daily budget field set to '20.00' USD and an estimated monthly budget of '608.00 USD'; and 'Optimization strategy' with a radio button selected for 'Increase bids for new customers', showing a conversion value of '\$888.00 (Account-level setting)'. Below this, there are tabs for 'Existing audience lists' with options 'remarketinglist1', 'abc', and 'Dynamic Q'. A blue banner at the bottom states: 'For clearer performance insights, adjust only one setting per experiment. Changes to budget are disabled for your treatment campaign.' At the bottom right are 'Save' and 'Cancel' buttons.

Step 4: Evaluate A/B test results

Compare results and use statistical significance to decide whether to apply the experiment, allow it to finish, or end it early.

- Review the experiment results page to compare performance metrics between your treatment and original campaigns.
- Use the color-coded **Difference** and **Difference %** rows to quickly assess performance:
 - Green:** Your experiment is winning
 - Gray:** Results are inconclusive
 - Red:** Your original campaign is winning
- A 95% confidence interval is displayed to show whether results are statistically significant
- A line chart visualization makes it easy to compare treatment vs control over time
- Based on performance, you can apply the experiment early, wait until it ends, or end it early.



Step 4: Apply your experiment

- Click **Apply experiment** button to make the treatment your primary campaign.
- Choose whether to **apply results to**:
 1. The original control campaign
 2. A new campaign

Note: If applied before the experiment ends, the experiment will stop and the winning setup will be applied.

You can apply your experiment at any time. Applying an experiment while it is still running will automatically end the experiment.

← Back PMAX Feature Guide Exp Feb 20-27 2026 Edit Apply experiment End experiment early

Performance Max Optimization
Experiment is running Running 64 days remaining

Start and end dates 4/3/2026 - 6/6/2026 Split type Cookie-based Traffic split (control/treatment) 50/50 Confidence interval 95%

Performance comparison

Key metric comparison

Apply experiment to:

- ☒ Your control campaign (PMAX Feature Guide) will adopt the settings of the treatment campaign (PMAX Feature Guide Exp). Treatment will be paused.
- ☐ We'll create a new campaign with the same budget as your existing one (PMAX Feature Guide). It'll adopt the settings of the treatment campaign (PMAX Feature Guide Exp). Control will be paused.

Apply experiment Go back

Campaigns	Type	Objective	Budget	Conversion goal	Locations
PMAX Feature Guide	Performance Max	Maximize conversions	\$20.00/day	Begin checkout	Canada (country/region) and United States...
PMAX Feature Guide Exp	Performance Max	Maximize conversions	\$20.00/day	Begin checkout	Canada (country/region) and United States...

Step 4: End your experiment early

- If you're not happy with the results of your experiment and don't need to test any further, you can click **End experiment early**.

The screenshot displays the Microsoft Advertising interface for an experiment titled "PMax Feature Guide Exp". The interface includes a top navigation bar with a "Back" button, the experiment name, a date range "Feb 20-27 2026", and buttons for "Edit", "Apply experiment", and "End experiment early".

The main content area shows the experiment status as "Running" with "64 days remaining". It also displays the start and end dates (4/3/2026 - 6/6/2026), the split type (Cookie-based), the traffic split (50/50), and the confidence interval (95%).

Below this, there are sections for "Performance comparison" and "Key metric comparison", both of which indicate "No experiment metrics data available".

A modal dialog box is open in the center, asking "Are you sure you want to end your experiment?". The dialog includes a warning: "PMax Feature Guide Exp will stop running. Once you stop an experiment, it cannot be restarted." and two buttons: "End experiment" and "Cancel".

At the bottom, there is a table listing the campaigns:

Campaigns	Type	Bid strategy	Budget	Conversion goals	Locations
PMax Feature Guide	Performance Max	Maximize conversions	\$20.00/day	Begin checkout	Canada (country/region) and United States...
PMax Feature Guide Exp	Performance Max	Maximize conversions	\$20.00/day	Begin checkout	Canada (country/region) and United States...

Frequently asked questions

- | | | |
|----|---|--|
| 01 | What can I test with optimization experiments? | Bid strategies, feed changes, audience strategies, creative assets, and targeting updates, depending on campaign type and experiment support. |
| 02 | How long should experiments run? | <ul style="list-style-type: none">- Run A/A mode for 2–4 weeks to establish a stable baseline to ensure A/B testing can be properly attributed to your test variable- Then run A/B mode for at least 2 weeks, ideally 4, depending on campaign volume and type. |
| 03 | Why do I need A/A mode? | A/A mode ensures both campaigns perform similarly before testing changes, making A/B results more reliable. |
| 04 | Can I test multiple changes in the treatment campaign at once? | It's best to test one major variable at a time so performance differences can be attributed to a single change. |
| 05 | Can I change budget during an experiment? | You can't change experiment budget. To change budget, you need to update the original campaign budget. Spend will then be divided according to the new split setting. |

Frequently asked questions

- | | | |
|----|--|---|
| 06 | What if my campaign has low volume? | Low-volume campaigns may need longer test durations to reach statistically significant results. Campaigns with fewer conversions may produce inconclusive results more often. |
| 07 | Can the same campaign be used in multiple experiments at the same time? | No. A campaign cannot participate in multiple active experiments at the same time |
| 08 | Are shared or lifetime budgets supported? | No. Campaigns using shared or lifetime budgets are not currently supported for optimization experiments |
| 09 | Where do I view experiment results? | Results are available on the experiment results page, where you can compare treatment and control performance, review confidence intervals, and assess lift. |
| 10 | How do I know when results are statistically significant? | Review the results scorecard for performance differences and confidence intervals to determine statistical significance. |

Thank you